Sri Lankan citizenship, half a million would be repatriated to India and the situation for the 1,50,000 remaining would be decided later. The programme was phased over fifteen years, but in the end not everyone was repatriated as planned.

The Sri Lankan Tamils, on the other hand, resisted Sinhalese power. In 1976, a militant organization called Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE) was formed in north-eastern Sri Lanka, demanding a separate state for the Tamilians. Since 1983, a serious armed conflict began against the government. Just as the Bangladeshi separatist movement appealed to Indian Bengalis, the LTTE found support among many Tamilians and influential political parties in Tamil Nadu, but the similarity and support base ended there. India's complex involvement in Sri Lankan affairs in the late 1980s, from relief to peacekeeping missions to demobilization of militant groups led to a fierce backlash culminating in the assassination of former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi in 1991 by LTTE operatives. The LTTE was finally decimated by the Sri Lankan army in 2009, ending a twenty-six-year civil war that was waged in different phases, each prompting an exodus of refugees to Tamil Nadu.

The Sri Lankan civil war prompted mass displacement among the Tamilians, both internally, towards India and around the world. The first Ealam War (1983–88) brought in over a 1,00,000 refugees into Tamil Nadu.[61] Most of these refugees went back to Sri Lanka but another 1,00,000 came in 1990–91 with the outbreak of the second Ealam War (1990–94). These included many who were making their second trip to India as refugees within a decade. After Rajiv Gandhi's assassination, the refugee exodus was blocked by the Indian navy for a brief period, and the Tamil Nadu government began to cut down on the number of refugee camps. The next violent uprising in Sri Lanka in the late 1990s, and again between 2006 and 2009, witnessed a relatively smaller refugee influx.

While fleeing to India, almost all the refugees ended up at Dhanushkodi Island in Ramanathapuram district of Tamil Nadu. After due inspection and registration, they were dispatched to the Mandapam transit camp, and from thereon to one of the numerous refugee camps scattered across Tamil Nadu.